

The Thief of Bagdad stars Douglas Fairbanks and a cast of thousands in an early and lavishly produced **swashbuckling adventure fantasy**.

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1924

Alfred Hitchcock's first thriller, *The Lodger: A Story of the London Fog*, about the hunt for Jack the Ripper, is a commercial hit in the UK.

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1927

The Jazz Singer is the first movie with **synchronized sound dialogue**. It mixes title cards with short sound sequences.

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1927

Josef von Sternberg's *The Blue Angel* is released in German- and English-language versions, and makes **Marlene Dietrich** a worldwide star.

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1930

1925
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Sergei Eisenstein's **technical masterpiece** *Battleship Potemkin* is released to mark the 20th anniversary of the 1905 Russian Revolution.

1927
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Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* is one of the first **full-length science-fiction** movies, set in a technologically advanced dystopian future.

1929
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The **first Academy Awards** ceremony is held at the Hollywood Roosevelt Hotel in Los Angeles.

1931
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Charlie Chaplin **defies the talkie revolution** with his hit silent classic *City Lights*.

Painters were also drawn to the screen, and in 1929, the famed Surrealist Salvador Dalí worked with a young movie fanatic named Luis Buñuel on the eternally strange *Un Chien Andalou*; Dalí then stepped away from movies, but Buñuel continued making iconoclastic movies into the 1970s. There were revolutionaries of the political kind, too. In the Soviet Union, cinema was embraced as *the* art form of the people. Movies became key to the global battle for hearts and minds.

Hollywood begins

Back in America, the cinematic hustlers became the first studio bosses of Hollywood. They built their businesses on stars such as Rudolph Valentino, Douglas Fairbanks, and Greta Garbo.

“
Charlie Chaplin and I would have a friendly contest: Who could do the feature film with the least subtitles?
”
Buster Keaton

The biggest stars were clowns, and of all the wonders of the silent age, it is the comedies that most reliably delight today. In Buster Keaton and Charlie Chaplin, Hollywood found two true geniuses who had honed

their craft in American vaudeville and British music hall and now worked their magic on camera. Masters of mime, slapstick, and pathos, they could make audiences laugh just by looking at them. They were also meticulous filmmakers with a taste for innovation.

If one person defined the early movies, it was the phenomenally famous and endlessly ambitious Chaplin. By the end of this era, sound arrived—it was 1927 when Al Jolson declared in *The Jazz Singer*: “You ain’t heard nothing yet!” But Chaplin’s love for silent movies was such that he kept making them, and in 1931, with *City Lights*, he made one of the very greatest. By then, he had already helped the movies claim their rightful place, where they still are today—in the center of people’s lives. ■